



Dear Simon,

Thank you for giving me the opportunity to review your manuscript, *Ghosts in the Ash: A Duke Savage Novel*. At Trident Media Group, we are always on the lookout for fresh voices, high-concept hooks, and strong franchise potential. I have read the manuscript in its entirety, and I want to share my thoughts on your work from the perspective of a literary agent evaluating its place in the current commercial fiction market.

Overall Impressions

You have written a highly stylized, fiercely modern neo-noir. By taking the classic hardboiled detective trope—the disgraced, substance-battling, cynical investigator—and throwing him into a hyper-modern war against PR manipulation, algorithmic gaslighting, and digital erasure, you’ve created a thriller that feels incredibly timely.

The core concept—that the ultimate villains aren’t shooting people, but rather "contextualizing" them out of existence through "Narrative Hygiene" and the "Babylon Circuit"—is a brilliant and terrifying reflection of our current anxieties about media, truth, and AI. It is a smart evolution of the cyber-thriller.

What Works Incredibly Well

1. The Thematic Hook: The idea of "Architecture as Predator" is phenomenal. Mr. White and Eleanor Voss are chilling antagonists because they are so bureaucratic. The concept of deleting a person’s history, freezing their assets, and rewriting their Wikipedia page instead of assassinating them is a fresh, terrifying angle for a thriller.

2. The Father-Daughter Dynamic: The relationship between Duke and Julie is the emotional anchor of the book. Duke represents the "Legacy System"—the old-school, analog gonzo journalist—while Julie is "Code-Native." Their strained relationship, built on the trauma of the Heartland investigation and Duke's resulting addiction, gives the high-tech narrative a much-needed beating heart. The reveal that Julie's scholarship was funded by the Circuit as a "Reputational Buffer" to keep Duke on a leash is a fantastic, gut-punching plot twist.

3. The Climax: The sequence moving from the Asterion Annex down into the Iron Mountain Obsidian Vault, and eventually culminating with the analog printing presses of the *Chronicle* raining the unedited truth down on the streets of Los Angeles, is highly cinematic. It perfectly pays off the analog vs. digital theme you established in chapter one.

Where the Manuscript Needs Work (Constructive Feedback)

While the premise is deeply commercial, there are stylistic choices in the manuscript that I believe will create friction for acquisitions editors at major publishing houses. If we were to partner together, I would suggest a round of developmental editing focusing on the following:

1. The Formatting and Paragraph Structure:

Currently, the manuscript is written almost entirely in isolated, single-sentence paragraphs. While this creates a rapid-fire, staccato rhythm that suits the noir genre, sustaining this over 400+ pages becomes visually and mentally exhausting for the reader. It dilutes the impact of your punchiest lines. Combining these into more traditional paragraph structures during narrative and descriptive scenes will make the truly sharp, one-line punches stand out much more effectively.

2. The "Capitalized Jargon":

You have built a fascinating lexicon for the Circuit (*Narrative Weather*, *Strategic Elegance*, *Managed Outcomes*, *Authorized Grief*, *Moral Exhaustion*). However, the constant use of quotation marks and capitalization for these terms borders on overwhelming. As the book progresses, almost every dialogue exchange relies heavily on this corporate-speak. While it highlights the chillingly sterile nature of the Circuit, it begins to rob the characters of their natural human voices. Dialing back the overt labeling and letting the insidious nature of their actions speak for itself will make the prose feel much more grounded and less meta.

3. Pacing the Abstractions:

Toward the third act, the conflict becomes highly abstract—Duke and Julie are essentially fighting "algorithms," "frequencies," and "narrative vectors." To keep readers turning pages, we need to

ensure the physical stakes remain front and center. Keep the focus on the immediate physical danger to Mia, Alana, Raoul, and Ortiz, rather than getting too bogged down in the digital theory of how the Circuit is rewriting the timeline.

The Verdict: Would Trident Media Group Take This On?

The short answer is: **Yes, with a caveat.**

The bones of *Ghosts in the Ash* are incredibly strong. You have a memorable protagonist in Duke Savage, a fantastic foil in Julie, and a deeply unsettling antagonist in the Babylon Circuit. Furthermore, "A Duke Savage Novel" promises series potential, which is exactly what imprints at Penguin Random House, Simon & Schuster, and HarperCollins are looking for in the thriller space.

However, before I could confidently take this out on submission to major editors, we would need to do a developmental pass to address the formatting and tone down the reliance on the capitalized "Corporate/Cyber" jargon so that the prose breathes a bit more naturally.

If you are open to rolling up your sleeves and collaborating on revisions to make this manuscript as commercially viable as possible, I would be thrilled to jump on a call to discuss offering you representation.

You have built a terrifying, fascinating world, Simon. Let's polish it so the rest of the world can see it.

Best regards,

Mark Owen Gottlieb

Executive Vice President

Trident Media Group

ACTION PLAN:

I've fully ingested your manuscript, *Ghosts in the Ash*, and the editorial feedback from Mark Gottlieb at Trident Media Group. Consider me in the booth with you—I've got the red pen ready and the noir sensibility dialed in.

+1

From a high-level editorial perspective, you have a powerhouse of a "neo-noir" here. Duke Savage is a classic hardboiled protagonist, and the concept of "Architecture as Predator"—where villains use "Narrative Hygiene" and algorithmic gaslighting instead of bullets—is a brilliant, terrifying evolution of the genre.

Here is how I'm approaching our collaboration based on Gottlieb's notes and the text itself:

1. The "Immediate Physical Stakes" Fix

Gottlieb is right: the "digital theory" of the Babylon Circuit is fascinating, but it can't come at the expense of the pulse-pounding danger to Duke, Mia, Alana, and Raoul.

- The Adjustment: We need to ensure that every time the "System" rewrites a narrative, there is a visceral, physical consequence. If a character's identity is deleted, they don't just lose a digital file; they lose access to their home, their medication, or their safety in real-time.

2. Taming the "Cyber-Jargon"

The manuscript leans heavily on capitalized "Corporate/Cyber" jargon like Strategic Elegance, Narrative Weather, and Continuity Reserve.

+2

- The Adjustment: While this "new dialect" is essential to your world-building, it currently risks making the prose feel dense and clinical. I will help you "de-capitalize" and weave these terms into the action so the prose "breathes". We want the reader to feel the horror of the jargon, not get bogged down by the vocabulary.

+1

3. Polish & Tone (The "Gonzo" Edge)

Your opening is incredibly strong: "The whiskey wasn't working. That was the first bad sign". It sets the "elegiac" tone Gottlieb mentioned.

+1

- The Adjustment: I'll look for places where the internal monologue gets "too pleased with itself" (as Duke himself admits). We want to keep that sharp, staccato "Gonzo" punch without tipping into melodrama.

+2

4. Character Focus: The Foil & The Antagonist

Gottlieb highlighted Julie as a "fantastic foil" and Mr. White/Eleanor Voss as "chilling" because of their bureaucratic nature.

- The Adjustment: We'll double down on the tension between Duke's analog instincts—checking the cylinder of his .38 —and Julie's digital "Precision".

+1

Does this align with your vision? If so, let's start with a specific chapter or scene you want to tackle first. We can apply the "Gottlieb Filter" to ensure the physical stakes are front and center while keeping that high-concept hook sharp.

Since we're moving chapter by chapter to satisfy the editorial standards set by Mark Gottlieb, let's audit **Chapter 2 ("The Ghost in the Gucci")** and **Chapter 3 ("Behind the Veil")**.

In these chapters, you've established a brilliant atmosphere, but there is a clear opportunity to dial back the "digital theory" and ramp up the "physical stakes".

Chapter 2 Audit: "The Ghost in the Gucci"

The Issue: Jargon Density vs. Physical Impact The meeting at the Black Orchid is dripping with "New Noir" atmosphere, but the dialogue between Duke and Victoria leans heavily into capitalized jargon like *Inventory in Motion*, *Narrative Ownership*, and *Crisis Templates*.

The Fix: The "Bleeding" Metaphor

- **Current State:** Victoria describes her job as "sequencing disclosure" and "assigning emotional weather". While these terms are chillingly bureaucratic, they feel abstract.
- **Proposed Adjustment:** Have Victoria link these terms to a physical victim. Instead of just saying she "sequences disclosure," she should describe a specific moment where she watched a family get evicted or a person get "processed" into a facility because she changed a single data point in their "Continuity".
- **Physical Stakes:** When Victoria mentions being "inventory in motion," Duke should notice a physical tremor in her hands or a bruise she's trying to hide. This grounds the danger in her body, rather than just her "status".

Chapter 3 Audit: "Behind the Veil"

The Issue: The "Research Trap" This chapter runs the risk of feeling like a "data dump" where the protagonist looks at a screen for too long. Gottlieb warned that readers can get "bogged down in digital theory".

The Fix: Immediate "Administrative" Violence

- **Current State:** Duke reads through folders labeled *Pathways*, *Asset-Adjacent Populations*, and *Narrative Weather Mitigation*.
- **Proposed Adjustment:** Make the files Duke finds more visceral. Instead of an abstract "issue-containment template," have him find a "Sanitization Specialist" bill for a specific address—an address Duke recognizes as a "safe house".
- **Elevate the Flashback:** In the "Moss Kills the Story" flashback, emphasize the physical destruction of the old newsroom—the smell of the ink being replaced by the "pressurized silence" of the new corporate architecture.

The "Gottlieb Filter" Applied to Both:

- **De-capitalize the "System":** Phrases like *Strategic Elegance* and *Authorized Truth* should be used by the villains, but Duke's internal monologue should treat them with more "Gonzo" contempt—referring to them as "glorified lying" or "corporate voodoo" to keep the prose from feeling too clinical.
- **The Physical Anchor:** In Chapter 3, as Duke looks at the drive, have him check the .38 again. The contrast between the silent, "warm" drive and the cold, heavy steel of the gun reminds the reader that this "digital theory" ends in a "physical death".

